

Massachusetts Institute of Technology — Brain and Cognitive Sciences (Course 9) + STS Minor

Program Dossier · Prepared for Eidee Tan & Family · Fall 2027 Entry · Research date: August 15, 2026

This pathway pairs MIT’s Bachelor of Science in Brain and Cognitive Sciences (“Course 9”) — a rigorous science-of-mind degree that already builds in Python, statistics, neural computation, and required laboratory research — with the six-subject minor in Science, Technology, and Society (STS), which supplies the historical, ethical, and political lens a future technology lawyer needs. It exists at MIT because the Department of Brain and Cognitive Sciences treats the mind as something to be explained mechanistically, and because MIT’s humanities requirement is large enough (eight subjects) to hold a real second pillar. The single most important thing for the family to know: **admission is to MIT as a whole — students select any major freely at the end of the first year, with no internal admission gate** (MIT Admissions FAQ), so this entire academic plan is structurally available to every admitted student. The competitive gates come earlier (MIT admission itself, **4.6% admit rate for the Class of 2029**) and later (research placements and the music-lesson fellowship, both auditioned or applied-for).

1. The university at a glance

Fact	Detail	Source
Location / type	Cambridge, Massachusetts; private research university on the Charles River facing Boston	MIT Facts
Identity line	“Mens et Manus” (mind and hand) — science and engineering learned by building and doing; ~93% of graduates do faculty-mentored research	UROP — About
Undergraduate enrollment	4,561 undergraduates (October 2025), alongside 7,255 graduate students	MIT Enrollment Statistics
Overall admit rate	4.6% — 1,334 admitted from 29,281 first-year applicants (Class of 2029, Fall 2025 entry)	MIT Admissions Stats
Test policy	SAT or ACT required for all first-year applicants	Tests & Scores
SAT mid-50%	Math 780–800 , ERW 740–780 ; ACT 34–36 (Class of 2029)	MIT Admissions Stats
Application platform + fee	MIT’s own application (apply.mitadmissions.org — MIT does not use the Common App); fee \$75 , waivers freely available	Deadlines & Requirements; Fee FAQ
Deadlines	Early Action: November 1 (decisions mid-December); Regular Action: January 4 (decisions mid-March). EA is non-binding and non-restrictive	Deadlines & Requirements; Early vs. Regular

Fact	Detail	Source
Financial aid headline	Need-blind; meets 100% of demonstrated need . From 2025–26: tuition-free below \$200,000 family income; \$0 parental contribution below \$100,000 (typical assets)	Affordability ; MIT announcement ; Fee FAQ (need-blind)

2. The big picture — what kind of place this is

MIT is a science-and-engineering university with a maker’s temperament: the motto “mens et manus” is lived out in a culture where understanding something means being able to build it, model it, or measure it. That culture extends to the study of the mind. MIT’s Department of Brain and Cognitive Sciences describes its mission as understanding “how the mechanisms of the brain give rise to the mind,” and its home, Building 46, as “the largest neuroscience research facility in the world,” housing roughly 700 researchers together with the McGovern Institute for Brain Research and the Picower Institute for Learning and Memory ([About BCS](#)). For a student whose intellectual home is cognitive science and whose destination is technology law, this is a place to learn how intelligence — human and artificial — actually works, before arguing about how it should be governed.

Every undergraduate, regardless of major, completes the General Institute Requirements (GIRs): a six-subject science core (two calculus, two physics, one chemistry, one biology), **eight subjects in humanities, arts, and social sciences (HASS)** including a three-to-four-subject concentration, two Restricted Electives in Science and Technology (REST), a laboratory subject, four communication-intensive subjects (two CI-H, two in the major), and physical education with a swim test ([General Institute Requirements](#)). The eight-subject HASS requirement is the structural reason an STS minor fits inside this degree rather than on top of it.

The first year is deliberately cushioned. Fall term is graded **Pass/No Record** — a C or better simply appears as “P,” and anything below vanishes from the external transcript — with a credit limit of 54 units (plus 6 units of discovery subjects); spring moves to A/B/C/No Record with a 60-unit limit ([Credit Limits & Grading](#)). Students apply to MIT, not to a major or school: “Students apply to MIT for general admission and select a major at the end of the first year,” and the “course of interest” named on the application carries no weight in admission ([Majors FAQ](#)). **There is no internal admission to Course 9 — declaring it is a free choice.**

What makes MIT uniquely strong for the cognition → AI → law direction is the combination of mechanistic depth and an institutionalized research pipeline. The Undergraduate Research Opportunities Program (UROP), founded in 1969, is the oldest program of its kind; **93% of the Class of 2025 did at least one UROP**, over 3,200 undergraduates participated in 2024–25, and MIT allocated \$16.8 million to paid positions ([About UROP](#)). MIT’s pre-law advising is explicit that “lawyers with a STEM background are at an advantage” in fields like intellectual property and AI law ([CAPD — Law](#)).

Music at MIT is serious and heavily subscribed, not an afterthought. The Music and Theater Arts section runs auditioned ensembles — MIT Symphony Orchestra, Chamber Music Society, choruses, jazz — plus a merit-based private-lesson program (Emerson/Harris) and a full six-subject Music minor ([Auditions](#); [Music & Theater Arts catalog](#)). Details in Section 6.

3. The program — Brain and Cognitive Sciences S.B. (Course 9) + STS minor

Bachelor of Science in Brain and Cognitive Sciences (Course 9)

Home unit: Department of Brain and Cognitive Sciences, School of Science. All details below are from the [Course 9 degree chart](#) in the 2025–26 catalog, the latest edition published at research time; the 2026–27 edition should be re-checked when it

posts.

Course 9 is for students who want the science of mind and brain whole — psychology, neuroscience, and computation in one degree — rather than sliced into separate majors. The departmental program (168–174 units beyond the GIRs’ contribution, out of 180 total units required beyond the GIRs) has four blocks:

Required subjects (60 units). Computation is mandatory, not optional: **6.100A Introduction to Computer Science Programming in Python** and **6.100B Introduction to Computational Thinking and Data Science** (6 units each); **9.00 Introduction to Psychological Science**; **9.01 Introduction to Neuroscience**; **9.40 Introduction to Neural Computation**; and a dedicated statistics subject, **9.07 Statistics for Brain and Cognitive Science** (or 18.05/18.600 from Mathematics).

Tiered electives (seven subjects, 84 units). Students “select seven subjects from the Tier II, Tier III, or Restricted Elective categories,” with **at least three from Tier II** — the department’s intermediate core. Signature choices relevant to Eidee’s direction include **9.13 The Human Brain**, **9.35 Perception**, **9.19 Computational Psycholinguistics**, and **9.66 Computational Cognitive Science** ([Course 9 subject listing](#)). This tier structure is what makes the major coherent rather than a pile of electives: breadth is forced at the intermediate level, then depth is chosen.

Laboratory requirement (12 units). One of **9.12** (Experimental Molecular Neurobiology), **9.17** (Systems Neuroscience Laboratory), **9.59[J]** (Laboratory in Psycholinguistics), or **9.60** (Machine-Motivated Human Vision) — all communication-intensive (CI-M), so scientific writing is built in.

Research requirement (12–18 units). A second, separate research experience chosen from the lab subjects above or from **9.41**, **9.50 Research in Brain and Cognitive Sciences**, or **9.URG Undergraduate Research** — meaning supervised original research (typically a UROP taken for credit) is a graduation requirement, not an extra. The same subject cannot satisfy both laboratory and research.

Alternative worth knowing: Course 6-9, Computation and Cognition. MIT also offers a joint **Bachelor of Science in Computation and Cognition (Course 6-9)** run by BCS with Electrical Engineering and Computer Science, requiring subjects such as 18.06 Linear Algebra and 6.3900 Introduction to Machine Learning alongside neuroscience ([Course 6-9 degree chart](#)). Choose 6-9 if building AI systems becomes the center of gravity; choose Course 9 if the human mind stays the object of study and computation remains the toolkit. For a cognitive-science-driven lawyer, Course 9 preserves more room for psychology, language, and perception — and more schedule room for STS. Switching between the two later is administratively straightforward since majors are freely declared.

Minor in Science, Technology, and Society (STS)

Home unit: STS Program, School of Humanities, Arts, and Social Sciences. The minor is **six subjects (57–72 units)**, per the [STS section of the catalog](#) (2025–26): the gateway **STS.004 Intersections: Science, Technology, and the World**; one further Tier I subject — options include **STS.001 Technology in American History**, **STS.005[J] Data and Society**, **STS.006[J] Bioethics**, and **STS.012[J] Science in Action**; one subject from the more specialized Tier II list; and three additional electives drawn from either tier. There is no thesis; the coherence comes from the tier design — a common foundation, then themed depth (for Eidee, plausibly data, computing, and governance).

MIT-wide minor rules: “Minors consist of five to seven subjects, with a typical program comprising six”; students apply **by the end of sophomore year** and no later than Add Date one full term before graduation; at most **two minors**; and — crucial for scheduling — for a HASS minor like STS, **up to five of the six subjects may also count toward the eight-subject HASS requirement** ([Minors, MIT catalog](#)). In practice the STS minor is largely *inside* the HASS requirement Eidee must complete anyway, which is why this combination is famously feasible.

4. How the pieces fit together

The load-bearing facts: (1) MIT admission is to the Institute, majors are **declared freely at the end of the first year** ([Majors FAQ](#)); (2) the STS minor rides mostly on the eight-subject HASS requirement, with up to five of six subjects double-counting ([Minors](#)); (3) Course 9's own research requirement means a UROP-for-credit can satisfy a graduation requirement rather than compete with one ([Course 9 chart](#)); (4) minor declaration is a form-based process aimed at the end of sophomore year — early enough to plan STS as a genuine second pillar. Scheduling reality: a typical term is four to five subjects (~48–60 units); Course 9 plus STS plus orchestra is a full but normal MIT load, protected in year one by Pass/No Record and credit limits ([Credit Limits & Grading](#)).

Gates beyond MIT admission — every step labeled:

Step	Type
Declaring Course 9 (end of first year)	Automatic — free choice, no internal admission (FAQ)
Declaring the STS minor (by end of sophomore year)	Requirements-based — application form to the minor program; no competitive selection published (Minors)
UROP research placements	Applicant-driven — proposals with a faculty supervisor; widespread (93% participation) but never guaranteed (UROP)
MIT Symphony / Chamber Music Society	Competitive audition each fall (Auditions)
Emerson/Harris private-study awards	Competitive audition , once a year before fall term (Emerson/Harris)
Optional Music minor	Requirements-based (Music catalog)

5. An illustrative four-year path

Illustrative only — not official advising; actual sequencing is set with a departmental advisor.

Year	Fall	Spring	Notes
1	GIR science core (calculus, physics), 9.00, first HASS; Pass/No Record , ≤54 units	GIR core continues, 6.100A, 9.01, HASS (possibly STS.004)	Ensemble auditions at start of fall; Emerson/Harris audition if ready. Declare Course 9 at year's end
2	9.40, 9.07, 6.100B, STS Tier I subject	Tier II Course 9 subject, STS Tier II subject, remaining GIRs	Declare STS minor by end of sophomore year. First UROP (pay or credit), possibly in Building 46 or CSAIL
3	Two Tier II subjects, STS elective	Lab subject (e.g., 9.59[J] Psycholinguistics or 9.60), Tier III elective, STS elective	UROP continues; aim it at cognition × AI (language models, decision-making, perception)
4	Research requirement via 9.50/9.URG (UROP for credit), Tier III electives	Final STS elective, remaining electives; LSAT window if applying to law school directly	CAPD pre-law advising and Pre-Law Society throughout (CAPD Law)

6. Beyond the classroom

Research. Course 9 students sit in the middle of the densest neuroscience-and-AI research corridor anywhere. Building 46 combines the BCS department with the **McGovern Institute for Brain Research** and the **Picower Institute for Learning and Memory** — about 700 researchers under one roof ([About BCS](#)). **CSAIL**, MIT’s computer science and AI laboratory, and the **Media Lab** also host undergraduates; the Media Lab states plainly that “there are opportunities for MIT undergraduates to engage with the Media Lab” while granting no undergraduate degrees ([Media Lab — MIT undergraduates](#); [CSAIL research](#)). Honest access note: all of these run on the UROP model — students find openings or pitch projects to faculty, “for pay or credit,” with UROP staff support but no placement guarantee ([UROP guidelines](#); [participation rules](#)). The 93% participation rate says access is normal, not exceptional — but a specific famous lab is never promised.

Law, policy, ethics. MIT has no law school, and no pre-law major — deliberately. Career Advising & Professional Development (CAPD) provides a dedicated pre-law advisor, a monthly pre-law newsletter, LSAT/LSAC guidance, and the student-run MIT Pre-Law Society; its advice is to major in what interests you most, noting the advantage STEM graduates hold in IP and AI law ([CAPD — Law](#)). The STS Program itself is the in-house scholarly community for technology-and-society questions, with subjects like Data and Society and Bioethics ([STS catalog](#)).

Violin and music life. Three layers matter for Eidee:

- **Ensembles.** The **MIT Symphony Orchestra** admits by recorded audition (for the 2026–27 season: video with a ≤3-minute solo plus scales, due August 31); the **Chamber Music Society** auditions live in early September with “two solo pieces of contrasting styles and a prepared excerpt” ([Auditions](#)). Ensembles carry academic credit as performance subjects.
- **Private study — Emerson/Harris Program.** MIT’s merit program funds private lessons for roughly 70 students a year at two levels. The **Scholars** level is “open to all full-time MIT students”: after a Scholar pays for and completes 10 fall-semester lessons, **MIT matches the cost of 10 spring lessons (up to \$1,200)**. The **Fellows** level is open to undergraduates “who have already completed one year of private study as a Scholar” (and to graduate students), with recital obligations; the page does not publish the Fellows award amount. **Auditions are held once a year, prior to the start of the fall semester**; awardees must register in an ensemble, attend a masterclass series, and perform in end-of-semester recitals ([Emerson/Harris Program](#)).
- **Academics.** A six-subject, 72-unit **Music minor** spans history/culture, composition/theory, and performance ([Music & Theater Arts catalog](#)) — an option, not part of this pathway, but compatible with it as a second minor if desired (two minors maximum).
- **In admissions.** MIT accepts optional **creative portfolios in SlideRoom for performing artists** (and researchers/makers) as part of the first-year application ([Deadlines & Requirements](#)) — the natural home for a violin recording and research abstracts.

Funding. UROP pays by the hour from a \$16.8M annual pool or faculty grants (one funding source per term) ([UROP rules](#); [About UROP](#)).

7. Access, feasibility, and honest risks

The admission gate is the pathway’s dominant risk. At 4.6% (Class of 2029), no profile makes MIT likely; everything in this dossier is conditional on that gate. After it, the structure is unusually open — no major admission, no minor competition — which is genuinely rare among Eidee’s options.

Workload physics. MIT’s science core (two physics, chemistry, biology) is non-negotiable and consumes much of year one. Course 9’s math/statistics expectations are real, and 9.40 (Neural Computation) is a known step up in technical intensity. Pass/No Record absorbs the transition, but a student who wants heavy orchestra involvement plus a UROP must budget terms carefully.

What is NOT included. There is no law, pre-law, or public policy major for undergraduates in this pathway, and MIT has no law school; the legal-institutional side is carried by STS subjects, HASS concentration choices, and CAPD advising — strong scaffolding, but Eidee supplies the direction. The seed dossier’s warning stands: STS must be treated as a genuine second pillar from year one, not a senior-year add-on, and Course 9 is a science degree, not an AI-engineering credential.

Named-lab access. UROP participation is near-universal, but placement in a specific celebrated lab (McGovern, CSAIL, Media Lab) depends on openings, fit, and persistence. Plan for “a strong cognition/AI UROP,” not “a specific PI.”

Music funding is partial. The Emerson/Harris Scholars award is a match up to \$1,200 after a self-paid fall of lessons — meaningful but not full coverage, and auditioned annually.

When a different MIT pathway would be better. If building models comes to outrank studying minds, **Course 6-9 (Computation and Cognition)** or Course 6-14 (CS, Economics, and Data Science) plus the same STS minor would serve the AI-law direction with a heavier engineering signature; the free-declaration system means this decision can be made with a year of real information.

8. Applying — logistics for Fall 2027

MIT uses **its own application portal** — not the Common App ([Deadlines & Requirements](#)). Dates below are as published on MIT’s admissions site at research time (August 2026); confirm against the site in fall 2026.

Item	Detail
Early Action	November 1, 2026 ; decisions mid-December. Non-binding, non-restrictive — “our Early Action isn’t single-choice, binding, or anything like that,” though other schools’ restrictive programs must be respected (Early vs. Regular). Students denied EA may not reapply RA the same year
Regular Action	January 4, 2027 ; decisions mid-March
Testing	SAT or ACT required. Latest test dates: November 30 for EA, December 31 for RA. MIT superscores (“we primarily consider the highest score achieved in each section”) and accepts self-reported scores, verified at enrollment (Tests & Scores)
Interview	Optional conversation with an alumni Educational Counselor (a 3,500-member volunteer network); offered after submission as availability allows; waived without penalty if unavailable (Interview)
Fee	\$75 , online; waivers available to domestic and international applicants, no effect on admission (Fee FAQ)
Other components	Essays; two teacher recommendations (one math/science, one humanities); Secondary School Report; February Updates & Notes form. Optional SlideRoom creative portfolio for performing artists — the vehicle for a violin supplement (Deadlines & Requirements)
Financial aid application	CSS Profile + IDOC tax documents (all students); FAFSA (domestic). Prospective-student deadlines: November 30 (EA) with offers mid-January; February 15 (RA) with offers mid-March (SFS — Apply for Aid)
Aid policy headline	Need-blind, 100% of need met; from 2025–26, tuition-free under \$200K family income and \$0 parental contribution under \$100K (typical assets); 88% of the Class of 2025 graduated debt-free (Affordability; MIT announcement, Nov 2024)

9. Sources

Admissions: [Deadlines & Requirements](#) · [Tests & Scores](#) · [Early vs. Regular](#) · [Interview](#) · [Admissions Stats](#) · [Application Fee FAQ](#) · [Majors FAQ](#) · [MIT Enrollment Statistics](#)

Program: [Course 9 degree chart](#) · [Course 9 subject listing](#) · [Course 6-9 degree chart](#) · [STS Program catalog \(minor\)](#) · [Minors — MIT catalog](#) · [General Institute Requirements](#) · [First-year credit limits & grading](#) · [About BCS / Building 46](#) · [About UROP](#) · [UROP guidelines](#) · [UROP participation considerations](#) · [Media Lab — MIT undergraduates](#) · [CSAIL research](#) · [CAPD — Law](#)

Music: [Emerson/Harris Program for Private Study](#) · [Performance auditions](#) · [Music & Theater Arts — MIT catalog](#)

Aid: [Affordability](#) · [SFS — Apply for Aid](#) · [Tuition-free announcement \(MIT, Nov 2024\)](#)